

6. Assess the view that children should be banned from using social media.

Keywords

- **Children:** Below 12 years old, or a young human being below the legal age of majority. The key traits of children relevant to the question are primarily (1) being vulnerable which include: immaturity, irresponsibility, naivety, gullibility, and (2) needing protection. Arguments should not associate children with young people/teenagers who are agents of change.
- **Should:** Consider the impacts of social media use by children and whether there is an obligation to safeguard the interests of children by banning them from using social media. There is a need to evaluate the purpose or feasibility of the ban instead of a pros and cons analysis of social media.
- **Banned:** to forbid (= refuse to allow) something, especially officially (enforced through legal, parental means)
- **Social media:** The key traits of social media relevant to the question are (1) the way it allows people to communicate and share information using the internet or mobile phones. Social media users can remain anonymous or create fictitious identities which has led to problems of impersonation scams, cyberbullying, and grooming; and (2) Social media is dominated by visual content that is presented to users based on algorithms which suggest related content to users to keep them engaged and entertained. The rapid consumption of interesting content has been said to lead to shortened attention spans and addiction to social media; and (3) Commercial entities have also used social media as a tool for targeted advertising. Online activists have also used social media to spread their agendas.

Question requirements

- Question carries the assumption that the use of social media is harmful to children and that there is a moral obligation to protect children from these harmful impacts
- Students need to consider whether these harmful effects are truly concerning to the point that it warrants a ban. Additionally, they should also consider the characteristics of children which will influence the severity of the harm inflicted on children and the necessity of protecting them.

Stand: While the use of social media do expose children to potential harms and negative influences, completely banning children from using social media may be too extreme and impractical.

Suggested Approach

- A. Acknowledge reasons why there is a perceived need to ban children from the use of social media
- B. Provide reasons for why banning children from the use of social media is actually impractical and it may be beneficial for children to continue using social media under supervision and monitoring.

Part A: Acknowledge reasons for the need to ban children from using social media

1. The content on social media is **largely unregulated** and children may be exposed to inappropriate content which may lead to traumatising experiences. This is due to the fact that children tend to be vulnerable as they lack emotional and intellectual maturity to process what they see.

Example:

According to a 2022 study done at Florida International University, the widespread coverage of disaster news on social media raises children's anxiety and trigger responses in their brains which puts them at risk of post-traumatic stress symptoms. This is exacerbated by the content on social media containing more graphic images and scenes than typically broadcast by more traditional news sources and the round-the-clock frequency of the news coverage. Younger children are especially vulnerable as they may not be able to distinguish between real immediate threats from irrational paranoia. Social media should thus be banned to avoid situations where children are traumatised.

2. Social media is **designed to capture the attention of its users** in order to generate profits for the social media companies themselves or their corporate investors. Interesting content suggested by the algorithms can result in users scrolling through social media for hours on end. Children should be banned from using social media as children are at the age where habits are being formed. Their lack of self-control and resultant addiction to social media can affect the healthy development of the child both physically and psychologically.

Example: A 2022 Wall Street Journal report showed that the consumption of social media especially Tik Tok which provides an endless stream of short and fast-paced video has negatively affected their attention spans. The inability to focus poses challenges to academic learning, decision-making and impulse control. There is therefore a need to ban children from using social media until they are mature enough.

3. **Membership in social media communities is gained through a common participation with** other members of the community. In bid to gain acceptance into communities, children may have the desire to mimic behaviours or adopt ideas which may at times be objectionable. As children are impressionable, banning them from social media will help regulate their behaviours.

Example: Many viral challenges of social media are extremely dangerous. Children who want to be perceived to be part of the trendy influencer group may engage in such challenges. For example, the ice and salt challenge involves putting both salt and ice on one's skin to see how long one can endure the pain of extreme low temperature burning one's skin. There have been cases of children obtaining third-degree burns as a result of the challenge.

4. Social media affords users with **anonymity and the ability to take on fictitious identities**. Online predators typically pretend to be someone close to the victim's age to establish a relationship with them before using emotional blackmail and coercion to pressure the victims into complying. Children are trusting and ignorant of the potential threats to their safety on social media. This renders them susceptible to exploitation.

Example: According to a 2018 report by digital education think tank DQ Institute, 16% of the respondents in Singapore aged between 8 and 12 had been involved in online sexual behaviours such as having searched for, and/or visited websites with sexual content, and/or having had sexual conversations online with strangers. 12% of the respondents said they had chatted with and met online strangers in real life.

Part B: Provide reasons for why banning children from the use of social media is actually impractical and it may be beneficial for children to continue using social media under supervision and monitoring

1. Banning children from social media does not guarantee that children will not be exposed to it. The banning of children from using social media may backfire due to the 'Forbidden fruit effect', where something becomes more attractive simply because it is not allowed. Children are curious and are increasingly resourceful. Social media can be easily accessed by children who can lie about their credentials or simply use devices or accounts belonging to others. Therefore, banning may not be the most practical solution and it is may be better if children are taught how to navigate the threats on social media.

Example: In a recent research conducted in the UK, by The Office of Communication (Ofcom), there is an astonishing 77% of social media users aged between eight and 17 who have their own account or profile on at least one of the large social media platforms. More children are signing up with a fake date of birth and these youngsters are defying age restrictions to go on social platforms. The survey found that children as young as three were using social media, in what Ofcom calls a "rise of the TikTots". And these social media platforms are unable to stop them.

2. Children may benefit from being exposed to social media at a young age. As a multimedia tool providing both visual and auditory engagement, coupled with the connectivity to other people all over the world, social media offers stimulating content that improves learning and exploration. Prohibiting children from using social media will mean denying them of these opportunities to engage with the world.

Example: Messenger Kids is Facebook's alternative for a more child-centric messaging app and platform. It allows children to message and video call their peers, but the main difference is that parents remain in control through Messenger Kids Parent Dashboard. Parents are able to review their children's chat and contact histories as well as remotely restrict their children access to the app.

Example: Kidzworld is one of the most comprehensive social media platforms, offering everything from free online arcade-style games and safe chat rooms to the latest movie and TV reviews. Children are able to create profiles, make friends, play games and even win prizes. There are the opportunities to read game reviews and cheats; to write blogs; create polls; and getting homework help.